

Smart Route Share

Making shared rides more predictable through rider-controlled detour limits

A self-initiated product design case for an Uber/Ola-style ride-hailing marketplace. This is a proposed concept, not a shipped feature or an official partnership.

The opportunity

Shared rides can lower costs, but extra pickups and uncertain detours can make arrival times difficult to trust. The motivating observation was a family experience in which unexpected shared-ride delays contributed to missing a train. That experience prompted the product question; it is not evidence of the problem's prevalence.

Product hypothesis

If riders can explicitly control the maximum extra pickup time they accept, and sharing is restricted to one compatible additional rider, they may be more willing to opt in without feeling they have surrendered control of their journey.

At a glance

User problem	Product response
Unpredictable detours	Rider A chooses an acceptable extra pickup-time tolerance
Too many intermediate stops	Only one additional rider may join
Unclear discount conditions	Fare reduction applies only after Rider B boards and verifies OTP
Premature matching	Matching begins only after Rider A's trip starts

Project status: requirements and proposed flows defined; no live marketplace data, usability study, prototype validation, or launch results claimed.

01 / Define the problem

Who is affected?

- **Primary:** Riders who want a lower fare but have a time-sensitive destination.
- **Secondary:** Riders willing to join an active ride to the same destination.
- **Marketplace:** Drivers and platform operations, whose capacity and route constraints determine feasibility.

Job to be done

“Help me save money on my ride without accepting an open-ended delay or surprise stops.”

Why this matters

A rider may perceive sharing as financially attractive yet avoid it when the arrival time is hard to predict. The product opportunity is not to invent pooled matching; it is to improve control and predictability within a constrained sharing experience.

What would validate the opportunity?

Question	Evidence to seek
Is unpredictable pickup delay a meaningful reason riders avoid sharing?	Rider interviews, opt-in and abandonment patterns
How much extra time will riders accept?	Tolerance selection distribution and actual trip behavior
Can compatible riders be matched often enough?	Same-destination eligible trip volume by location and time
Do savings offset perceived inconvenience?	Conversion, satisfaction and repeat-use metrics

These are validation questions, not findings. The originating anecdote and informal online discussion should not be presented as representative user research.

02 / Explore options and prioritize

Approach	Benefit	Tradeoff
Traditional multi-stop pooling	Potentially higher utilization	Greater route and arrival uncertainty
Guaranteed fixed arrival time	Clear customer promise	Difficult to guarantee under traffic and dispatch variation
Single extra rider + tolerance	Simple, rider-controlled constraint	Smaller match pool and potentially fewer discounts

Selected concept

Limit matching to one additional solo rider traveling to the same destination. Rider A chooses an illustrative 0-, 5-, or 10-minute maximum additional pickup-time tolerance. Candidate Rider B pickups must fit that limit based on the estimated incremental time at matching.

Why this tradeoff?

The concept deliberately sacrifices match volume to make the sharing proposition more predictable. It is intended for riders who value bounded disruption more than the lowest possible fare.

Key assumptions

- Enough trips share a practical destination for matches to occur.
- Pickup detour estimates are reliable enough to enforce a meaningful tolerance.
- The rider discount and second rider price can support acceptable unit economics.
- Driver, vehicle, route and consent constraints can be satisfied safely.

03 / Experience and matching logic

Proposed rider journey

Step	System behavior
1. Rider A books	Standard ride is booked; A opts into Smart Route Share and sets detour tolerance.
2. Trip starts	A boards and completes OTP verification; only then does B matching begin.
3. Match search	System filters for solo Rider B, same destination, free capacity, and pickup detour within A's tolerance.
4. Consent	Both riders must accept; match is not final without required consent.
5. B pickup	Driver collects B; B completes OTP verification.
6. Fare update	Only after B boards and verifies OTP does A receive the promised share discount.
7. Continue trip	No additional rider may join; trip proceeds to shared destination.

Candidate ranking

Among eligible Rider B candidates, rank by the smallest estimated incremental pickup detour, subject to feasibility and consent. This is a conceptual rule; production dispatch would need additional constraints and evaluation.

Important distinction

The 0/5/10-minute setting limits **estimated additional pickup detour at match time**; it does not guarantee that traffic or other delays will never affect the final arrival time.

04 / Pricing, exceptions and safety

Illustrative pricing example

Item	Example
Original Rider A fare	INR 400
A fare after verified B pickup	INR 320
B fare + service fee	INR 110 + INR 10 = INR 120

All amounts are illustrative. Pricing, driver earnings, incentives, and contribution margin would require financial validation.

Non-negotiable product rules

- No matching before Rider A's OTP verification and trip start.
- No fare discount based solely on a suggested or accepted match.
- If B does not board and verify OTP, A retains the original fare.
- Only one B may join; no further pickup requests after B joins.
- Consent and available seat capacity must be confirmed.

Failure and edge-case handling

Scenario	Proposed behavior
B cancels or no-shows	Cancel proposed share; keep A's original fare; continue A's trip.
Pickup estimate exceeds tolerance	Reject candidate before match offer.
Traffic worsens after match	Show revised ETA and provide clear support/cancellation policy; do not promise impossible guarantees.
OTP fails	Do not mark B boarded or apply A's discount.
Driver cannot safely stop	Do not force pickup; fall back to standard ride workflow.

05 / MVP, measurement and next decisions

MVP scope

- Rider A share opt-in and detour tolerance selection.
- Post-OTP eligibility search for one solo Rider B with same destination.
- Estimated pickup-detour filter and candidate ranking.
- Mutual consent, pickup state, B OTP, and conditional fare update.
- Clear trip status, revised ETA and failure handling.

Metrics that determine success

Metric	Why it matters
Share opt-in rate	Does the proposition attract riders?
Eligible match and completed-share rate	Is the constrained marketplace viable?
Estimated vs. actual added travel time	Does tolerance translate to predictability?
Cancellation and support-contact rate	Are riders experiencing confusion or disruption?
Contribution margin per shared trip	Does the economics work for the marketplace?
Repeat usage / rider satisfaction	Is trust sustained beyond first use?

Launch approach

Begin with a limited geography and time window, compare against existing ride options, monitor operational guardrails, and stop or revise the pilot if actual detours, cancellations, or economics breach thresholds. Specific thresholds require baseline data.

What I would do next

Validate demand and detour tolerance with riders; simulate match feasibility using permitted trip data; prototype the consent and fare states; partner with dispatch, safety, payments and operations teams to review failure modes.

Portfolio takeaway

This concept demonstrates problem framing, constraint-led product design, requirements definition, and explicit tradeoffs. It does not claim a launched product, verified retention lift, or real financial results.